

Word-count declaration

Manuscript: *A Comparability Protocol for Benchmarking Relational Database Access Layers in Express.js* (submission build `ist_main.tex`).

The official IST journal policy confirms a **15,000-word maximum for research papers**. The current author guidance supplied with this revision additionally assigns **200 words to each figure or table** and counts references and manuscript appendices. This declaration uses a deliberately conservative implementation of that rule.

Component
Seven body sections (<code>texcount</code> sum, including section headings and caption text encountered in those files)
Structured abstract (<code>texcount</code> sum)
Remaining front matter and required declarations (title/keywords, CRedit, competing interest, data availability)
Main-text tables and figures (2×200)
Rendered reference list (65 entries after removing 12 uncited ones; <code>pdftotext</code> count from the first entry to the last)
Conservative IST submission equivalent

The controlling total is therefore **14,996 words**, leaving **4 words of headroom** under the 15,000-word limit. The structured abstract contains 295 words under the `texcount` sum convention, below the 300-word limit.

The body grew by 521 words against the previous declaration. The additions are the new Study Design subsection documenting AI-assisted research tooling, which current publisher policy requires in the Methods section; a stated matched-utilization rank-inversion result; the driver-substitution caveat on the RQ2 reversals; and explicit limits on the external-audit codebook. Two offsetting reductions were made. First, prose was condensed and one redundancy removed: the residual left open by the unsatisfied implementation-review stage is now argued once, in Threats, with cross-references elsewhere. Second, two main-text floats moved to the online supplement — the estimand table, which the body had never cited and now cites as S47, and the insert-dispersion figure, which the supplement already carried — reducing the float allowance from seven to five and removing a duplicated figure.

Every `tabular` in the body now sits inside a numbered, captioned float, so the float allowance cannot be disputed: an earlier unnumbered tier schematic was folded into prose for exactly that reason.

The remaining headroom is 4 words. Any further addition requires an offsetting cut, and this declaration must be regenerated with it.

This total is intentionally stricter than a research-content-only count. It includes all required declaration text even though such text is commonly treated as submission metadata. It also retains caption words already encountered by `texcount` and then assigns the full 200-word allowance to every rendered float, so it does not undercount captions. The paper has no manuscript appendices. The separately submitted `supplement.pdf` is online supplementary material, not an appendix embedded in the research paper.

Reproduction commands:

```
sh cd paper/ist texcount -sum -brief ../sections/introduction.tex ../sections/related_work.tex
../sections/methodology.tex ../sections/results.tex ../sections/discussion.tex ../sections/threats.tex
../sections/conclusion.tex sed -n "43,68p" ist_main.tex | texcount -sum -brief - texcount
-inc -sum ist_main.tex rg -c "\{\}\bitem" ist_main.bbl rg -F "\{\}\@writefile{lot}"
ist_main.aux rg -F "\{\}\@writefile{lof}" ist_main.aux pdftotext ist_main.pdf - |
sed -n "/^References$/, $p" | wc -w
```

Count date: 30 July 2026, at the v1.13.0 release commit. Any later prose or float change requires this declaration to be regenerated.